

DUMP AND DUMPER

An FIR over graft allegations in granting mining leases fails to deter the chief minister who has the support of his party

■ By Ambreesh Mishra

Trucks threaten to roll over the political career of Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chauhan and his wife's nascent transport business, after the Madhya Pradesh Lokayukta registered an FIR on November 16 over the 'dumper scam' involving the chief minister, his wife Sadhna Singh and officials from the transport and mining department.

The FIR was the culmination of a three-month-long campaign by the Opposition. Initially raised by the Uma Bharati-led Bharatiya Janshakti, the issue of the ownership of four dumpers in a cement plant in Rewa was soon hijacked by the Congress. Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly Jamuna Devi who first filed a complaint before the state's anti-corruption ombudsman against Chauhan, later filed a writ petition before the Supreme Court seeking a CBI inquiry which was dismissed by a bench comprising Chief Justice K.G. Balakrishnan and Justice R.V. Raveendran on November 2.

On November 13, Congress functionary Ramesh K. Sahoo, who had earlier filed a similar complaint before the Lokayukta, moved a special anti-corruption court in Bhopal seeking directions that the Special Police Establishment (SPE) under the ombudsman register an FIR and investigate the case. In its order the same day, Special Judge (Prevention of Corruption Act) R.K. Bhawe ordered the SPE to conduct an inquiry and file a report by December 14.

Even as the ombudsman registered an FIR, the Congress raised a shrill demand for Chauhan's resignation for being the first-ever chief minister in the state to be slapped with an FIR in a graft case. Former chief minister Digvijay Singh, who has been on the



UNFAZED: Shivraj Singh Chauhan with wife Sadhna Singh

lookout for issues to stage a comeback into mainstream politics says: "It's for the first time that a chief minister and his wife are together facing serious graft charges. Chauhan should accept moral responsibility and step down."

Chauhan, who initially appeared to be unnerved, has refused to buckle under pressure. "I've done nothing wrong. It's not a crime for my family members to earn a living through

legitimate means," he said, buoyed by the solidarity shown by cabinet colleagues who urged him not to quit. The next day, Chauhan declared that he had the support of the BJP which had asked him not to resign.

Allegations against Chauhan centre over the affidavit he had submitted to the Election Commission during his election campaign for the Assembly seat in April 2006, which showed a sum of Rs 2.70 lakh in his and his wife's bank accounts without any mention of

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